ABCC 2027 Practice Case 2 — Boardroom Round

Manufaktur Lichtwerk: From Premium to Luxury?

Practice material — internal use only. This is an original fictional case written for ABCC 2027 preparation. Manufaktur Lichtwerk GmbH, its founders, advisors, customers and partners are invented; any resemblance to real persons or companies is coincidental. Competitor brands named for market context are real, but all figures relating to them are rounded, illustrative estimates for classroom use only. The case mirrors the structure and pressure profile of the ABCC 2026 Boardroom round (Coal & Canary).

Contents

- How to Run This Practice Round
- The Boardroom Brief
- THE CASE
  - 1. A Candle Poured Against the Weather
  - 2. The Product Today
  - 3. How Lichtwerk Sells
  - 4. The Market and the Competitive Set
  - 5. The Customer Picture
  - 6. Edition Eins: The €95 Experiment
  - 7. The Founders' Disagreement
  - 8. Decisions the Board Cannot Postpone
- EXHIBITS (CASE DATA)
  - Exhibit 1 — Pricing Ladder: Hero Candles, DACH Market
  - Exhibit 2 — Lichtwerk P&L Structure, FY2025
  - Exhibit 3 — Channel Economics, FY2025
  - Exhibit 4 — DTC Customer Segmentation (CRM, 24-month actives, n = 96,000)
  - Exhibit 5 — Brand Tracking, DACH Premium-Fragrance Buyers (Jan–Feb 2026, n = 2,100)
  - Exhibit 6 — The Founders' Maison Plan and Operating Constraints
- YOUR TASK

Then the coach-only teaching note — do not read it before you have presented.

How to Run This Practice Round

Parameter	Specification (mirrors ABCC Boardroom round)
Preparation time	**4 hours**, team of 4, sequestered from coach and outsiders; internet research **allowed** — including databases and generative AI — per official ABCC rules; no phones or smartwatches
Opening pitch	**3 minutes, uninterrupted**, hard stop; all four members must speak at some point in the session
Board discussion	**22 minutes**, moderated by the judges in role as the board; interruptions expected
Artifact 1	**One (1) summary slide**, 16:9, projected during the pitch and left on screen throughout
Artifact 2	**One-page judge brief**: A4, single side, **black-and-white**, minimum 10.5 pt type, ≥1.5 cm margins; handed to each judge before the pitch as a board pre-read
Artifact 3	Appendix slides in the same .pptx deck — **unlimited** per ABCC rules; may be shown **only** during the discussion, never during the 3-minute pitch
Weight	**30% of the overall competition score**
Judges	Four judges role-playing the board (see "The Board" below)

Coach's role: play the board chair, keep time ruthlessly, and interrupt.

The Boardroom Brief

You are a four-person strategy team engaged by the board of **Manufaktur Lichtwerk GmbH**, Hamburg. The board convenes at an offsite in the Speicherstadt on **7 August 2026**. You present to the full board: both founders and both advisory board members. They have read nothing in advance except the one-page brief you hand them. They are not an audience; they are a board — sceptical, informed, and short on time.

THE CASE

1. A Candle Poured Against the Weather

Manufaktur Lichtwerk was founded in Hamburg-Ottensen in 2015 by two friends: **Johanna Voss** (43), then a beauty-and-home buyer at a Hamburg department store, and **Merle Petersen** (39), a product designer trained at the HFBK Hamburg. The founding story is well rehearsed and genuinely true: during one of Hamburg's endless grey Januaries, Merle began hand-pouring candles in a shared studio because, as she puts it, "you cannot fix the sky, but you can fix the room." Johanna sold the first batch of forty candles in three hours from a stall at the Isemarkt.

The product had a point of view from day one. Rapeseed-coconut wax sourced from Schleswig-Holstein instead of imported soy or paraffin. Crackling beech-wood wicks. Heavy tumblers with brushed brass lids. Brass-capped beechwood matches in every gift box. And names that made northern Germans smile in recognition: *Schietwetter*, *Elbnebel*, *Feierabend*, *Landgang*, *Kontorhaus*. A 2018 feature in a national interiors magazine — "the candle that smells like a Hamburg Sunday" — sold out three months of production in eleven days.

Growth since then has been steady rather than spectacular: a webshop in 2019, a lockdown-driven DTC surge in 2020–21, painful wax and glass inflation in 2022, and a decision in 2023 that Johanna still defends and Merle still resents — listing on Amazon to clear seasonal overstock. Amazon was supposed to be temporary. It is now the company's fastest-growing channel.

In 2025 Lichtwerk generated **€6.8 million in revenue** (+8% year on year) with 47 employees, including 29 in the Ottensen manufaktur, where every candle is still poured, cured and labelled by hand. EBITDA was €0.37 million. The founders hold 46% each; **Hauke Brandt**, a Hamburg entrepreneur who exited a premium food brand, holds 8% as an angel and sits on the advisory board alongside **Dr. Katrin Sander**, former DACH managing director of a French beauty house.

2. The Product Today

The range is disciplined by indie standards:

- **Klassik Collection** — the core: 220 g candle, ~45 burn hours, **€39** RRP, eight permanent scents.
- **Stadtlichter Editions** — two seasonal drops per year, 220 g, **€42**, collectible labels.
- **Home fragrance** — reed diffusers (**€49**) and room sprays (**€29**), launched 2021, now 17% of revenue.
- **Gifting & accessories** — travel tins (€19), match bottles (€12), duo sets (€69), trays.
- **B2B / white label** — corporate gifting and private-label production for hospitality clients, including a Hamburg-based cruise operator that alone accounts for 22% of B2B revenue.

At €39, Lichtwerk sits comfortably above Rituals and Yankee Candle, and well below the luxury houses. That gap is the subject of this case.

3. How Lichtwerk Sells

Five channels carry the business (Exhibit 3). Direct e-commerce is the most profitable channel and, at 34% of revenue, second only to wholesale in size. The Ottensen atelier shop doubles as production theatre — customers watch candles being poured behind glass. Wholesale spans **380 doors** across DACH: concept stores, florists, book-and-lifestyle shops, and a handful of premium department-store corners; the top 40 doors produce 55% of wholesale revenue, and the bottom 200 average barely €3,300 a year each. Marketplaces — chiefly Amazon — are small but growing at 21%, fuelled by vouchers and retail-media spend, and plagued by two grey-market resellers who undercut RRP by up to 20%. B2B is quietly excellent cash flow and, in Merle's words, "brand-invisible at best."

4. The Market and the Competitive Set

European premium home fragrance grew roughly 7% annually from 2021 to 2025; the **luxury tier (€70+ candles) grew an estimated 11%**, driven by gifting, "affordable luxury" trading-up, and the post-pandemic

ritualisation of the home. The tier is dominated by houses with decades of codes: **Diptyque** (Paris, est. 1961), **Cire Trudon** (royal warrant heritage, est. 1643), **Byredo**, **Jo Malone London**, and at the apex **Fornasetti** and other design-house objects at €180+. Below Lichtwerk, **Rituals**, Yankee Candle and private labels (Zara Home, interiors e-tailers) compress the mid-market with €15–30 offers and constant promotion. Dr. Sander summarises the board's fear crisply: "The middle is where brands go to be eaten from both sides."

Germany is the awkward fact in the room. Luxury home fragrance is culturally Paris, London and Milan. No German candle brand has ever established itself in the luxury tier. Merle regards this as the opportunity — "Hamburg was Europe's warehouse of spices and scents for three hundred years; the provenance story is sitting in the Speicherstadt waiting for us." Johanna regards it as the warning.

5. The Customer Picture

A CRM segmentation of 96,000 active DTC customers (Exhibit 4) shows a base built on cosiness, not exclusivity: loyal self-purchasing **Ritualists**, seasonal **Gift Givers**, a small but valuable segment of design-driven **Aesthetes**, and promotion-hunting **Bargain Seekers** acquired largely through Amazon and sales.

A brand-tracking study fielded in January–February 2026 (n = 2,100 DACH premium-fragrance buyers; Exhibit 5) delivered a verdict the founders read very differently. Lichtwerk scores **higher than Diptyque on "authentic craftsmanship" (66 vs 55)** among those aware of it — and **24% call it "a luxury brand," against Diptyque's 74%**. The median acceptable price for a Lichtwerk 220 g candle is **€44**. Shown the Maison Lichtwerk concept at €95, 9% of the total sample would definitely or probably buy; among high-income luxury buyers, 27%. The most common verbatim: *"I love Lichtwerk, but €95 is a different world."*

6. Edition Eins: The €95 Experiment

In November 2025, Merle ran a pilot the board never formally approved. **Edition Eins**: 1,200 numbered candles — 300 g, mouth-blown smoked-glass vessel from a fourth-generation Bavarian Forest glasshouse, a 10% fragrance load composed by a Grasse perfumery house, hand-signed sleeve — at **€95**, DTC only. It sold out in eleven days with a 3,400-person waitlist and under 1% returns. 41% of buyers came from the existing top decile of customers; 38% were entirely new, with luxury-adjacent baskets. Gross margin: 62%. One blemish: 28% of buyers redeemed a standing 15% newsletter voucher, which Dr. Sander called "a price-integrity leak you cannot afford twice."

Merle's conclusion: the pilot proves a **Maison Lichtwerk** line can carry the company into luxury — six scents, a refill system (€38) as sustainability-as-luxury, selective distribution, a flagship on Neuer Wall. Her plan (Exhibit 6) requires **€1.4 million** over 24 months against **€0.61 million of cash** and modest profitability.

7. The Founders' Disagreement

The founders agree on the destination and disagree on everything else.

Merle wants a full pivot: reposition the entire brand toward luxury within three years, exit Amazon immediately, prune wholesale to under 100 curated doors, wind down white-label ("we are pouring anonymous candles for cruise-ship cabins while claiming to be a maison"), raise the Klassik price toward €49, and open the flagship in 2027.

Johanna wants the core protected: Klassik, wholesale and B2B fund every salary in Ottensen; the survey shows the customer ceiling at €44; and "luxury is a word other people use about you — declare it yourself at €6.8 million revenue and the market will laugh in French." She would run Maison as a contained experiment, keep Amazon "until it stops paying," and consider outside capital.

Into this stalemate arrived a letter in June: **Compagnie Sévigné**, a family-held French group owning niche fragrance and artisanal glassware maisons, proposes exploratory talks about a **minority investment of €2.5 million for 30%**, with access to its selective-distribution relationships and Grasse supply chain. Merle is intrigued despite herself. Johanna notes it values ten years of their lives at roughly one times revenue. Hauke wants the offer taken seriously. Dr. Sander wants it answered, either way, "like professionals — by October."

8. Decisions the Board Cannot Postpone

Three clocks are running:

1. **15 September 2026** — the glasshouse requires a binding reservation of its 2027 artisanal capacity slot (MOQ 5,000 vessels per order, 16-week lead time) for any autumn 2027 Maison launch.
2. **1 October 2026** — Hansen & Cie., a family-owned luxury department-store group with houses in Düsseldorf and Stuttgart, must receive an answer on its offer of a Maison Lichtwerk shop-in-shop for autumn/winter 2027.

3. **30 November 2026** — Lichtwerk's option on a small Neuer Wall retail unit (€450k fit-out estimate) expires.

And behind them, the Sévigné letter. The board meets on 7 August. You speak first.

EXHIBITS (CASE DATA)

All Lichtwerk figures are fictional. Competitor figures are rounded street-price estimates, spring 2026, for teaching purposes.

Exhibit 1 — Pricing Ladder: Hero Candles, DACH Market

Brand	Hero candle	Size	RRP (€)	€/100 g	Distribution character
Zara Home	Ceramic jar	200 g	16	8.0	Mass, own stores/online, frequent promotion
Yankee Candle	Large jar	538 g	35	6.5	Mass, broad wholesale, heavy discounting
Rituals	Private Collection	290 g	30	10.3	Mass-premium, ~1,000 own stores EU
Lichtwerk Klassik	*Elbnebel*	220 g	**39**	**17.7**	Premium; DTC, 380 wholesale doors, Amazon
Skandinavisk	ÖY	200 g	42	21.0	Premium Nordic, curated wholesale
Jo Malone London	Lime Basil & Mandarin	200 g	62	31.0	Luxury-adjacent; dept. stores, own boutiques
Diptyque	Baies	190 g	68	35.8	Luxury; boutiques, strict selective wholesale
Byredo	Bibliothèque	240 g	85	35.4	Luxury niche; selective
Maison Lichtwerk (proposed)	Edition line	300 g	**95**	**31.7**	TBD — the question of this case
Cire Trudon	Ernesto	270 g	110	40.7	Luxury heritage; selective, no discounting
Fornasetti	Otto	300 g	189	63.0	Design object; luxury dept. stores

Exhibit 2 — Lichtwerk P&L Structure, FY2025

By product line:

Product line	Revenue (€m)	Share	Gross margin %	Gross profit (€m)
Klassik candles	3.16	46.5%	52%	1.65
Stadtlichter seasonal	0.78	11.5%	55%	0.43
Home fragrance	1.16	17.0%	58%	0.67
Gifting & accessories	0.54	8.0%	47%	0.25
B2B / white label	1.16	17.0%	34%	0.40
Total	**6.80**	**100%**	**50.0%**	**3.40**

Below gross profit (€m): marketing 0.82 · non-production personnel 1.35 · rent & facilities 0.30 · logistics & fulfilment 0.38 · admin & other 0.18 → **EBITDA 0.37 (5.4%)**; D&A 0.11 → EBIT 0.26. Cash **0.61**; remaining KfW loan 0.21. Q4 delivers **43% of annual revenue**.

Unit economics, per candle (ex 19% VAT):

	Klassik 220 g (€39 RRP)	Maison 300 g (€95 RRP, pilot actuals)
Net revenue, DTC	32.77	79.83
Wax & fragrance	4.10	10.90 (Grasse oil, 10% load)
Vessel & lid	2.30	9.50 (mouth-blown)
Wick, label, packaging	1.70	4.60 (rigid box, sleeve)
Direct labour	2.80	4.20 (incl. finishing, numbering)
Total COGS	**10.90**	**29.20**
Gross margin, DTC	**€21.87 (67%)**	**€50.63 (63%)**

	Klassik 220 g (€39 RRP)	Maison 300 g (€95 RRP, pilot actuals)
Invoice price to wholesale	16.39 (50% trade margin)	35.92 (assumed 55% luxury trade margin)
Gross margin, wholesale	**€5.49 (33%)**	**€6.72 (19%)**

Exhibit 3 — Channel Economics, FY2025

Channel	Revenue (€m)	Share	YoY growth	Contribution margin*	Notes
DTC webshop	2.31	34%	+9%	38%	AOV €61; 96k active customers; 210k email list
Atelier store (Ottensen)	0.48	7%	+6%	30%	Production theatre; strong tourist traffic
Wholesale (380 doors)	2.52	37%	+3%	22%	Top 40 doors = 55% of wholesale; tail door avg. €3.3k p.a.
Marketplaces (Amazon et al.)	0.34	5%	+21%	21%	15% fees + 12% ads; voucher-driven; 2 grey-market resellers below RRP
B2B / corporate & white label	1.16	17%	+14%	26%	240 accounts; largest (cruise operator) = 22% of B2B
Total	**6.80**	**100%**	**+8%**		

*After channel-specific costs (trade terms, fees, advertising, fulfilment, retail staff), before shared overhead. Figures rounded to €0.01m; components may differ from the total by ≤ €0.01m.

Exhibit 4 — DTC Customer Segmentation (CRM, 24-month actives, n = 96,000)

Segment	% of customers	% of DTC revenue	AOV (€)	Orders/yr	12-mo repeat rate	"Would consider a €95+ Lichtwerk candle"
Ritualists (self-purchase regulars)	29%	41%	52	2.9	58%	12%
Gift Givers (Q4-heavy)	41%	33%	68	1.3	31%	9%
Aesthetes (design-led, urban)	12%	19%	86	2.2	47%	44%
Bargain Seekers (promo-acquired)	18%	7%	31	1.1	18%	2%

Edition Eins buyers: 41% existing top-decile customers (heavily Aesthetes), 38% new-to-brand, 21% reactivated; 28% redeemed a 15% newsletter voucher.

AOV and orders/yr are measured on the ~21,000 customers who transacted in the trailing 12 months (22% of the 24-month active base); segment revenue shares are of FY2025 DTC revenue (€2.31m, Exhibit 3).

Exhibit 5 — Brand Tracking, DACH Premium-Fragrance Buyers (Jan–Feb 2026, n = 2,100)

Attribute scores among respondents aware of each brand (% agreeing).

Brand	Aided awareness	"Is a luxury brand"	"Authentic craftsmanship"	"Worth a premium price"	"A prestigious gift"	Median acceptable price, 220 g (€)
Rituals	91%	18%	22%	26%	38%	26
Yankee Candle	78%	6%	12%	11%	14%	22
Jo Malone London	44%	69%	41%	52%	71%	58
Diptyque	31%	74%	55%	58%	66%	68
Manufaktur Lichtwerk	**21%**	**24%**	**66%**	**37%**	**41%**	**44**
Cire Trudon	12%	78%	72%	61%	63%	82

Lichtwerk awareness: 47% Hamburg metro vs 13% rest of DACH (the study deliberately oversampled the Hamburg metro to read home-market strength; the 21% overall aided awareness reflects that sample weighting,

not a DACH-representative average). Among Lichtwerk buyers, 71% describe the brand as "cosy/hyggelig," 19% as "exclusive." Maison concept test at €95: top-2-box purchase intent 9% (total sample), 27% (high-income luxury-buyer subsample, n = 312).

Exhibit 6 — The Founders' Maison Plan and Operating Constraints

Merle's investment plan (24 months, €k):

Item	€k
Brand identity, packaging design & tooling	180
Neuer Wall flagship fit-out	450
PR, sampling, launch events (Paris/Milan press days)	320
Vessel MOQ & launch inventory (working capital)	300
New hires: Maison brand lead, luxury key account, 2 artisans (total staffing cash within the 24-month window; hires phased from month 12)	150
Total cash requirement	**≈1,400**

Founders' Maison revenue plan: 2027 (H2 launch) €0.6m → 2028 €1.6m → 2029 €2.9m, at an assumed **blended gross margin of 60%** with a 70/30 DTC/selective-wholesale mix. Klassik and B2B assumed to keep growing at +4% p.a. throughout.

Operating constraints:

Constraint	Detail
Hand-pour capacity	9,000 candles/week (11,500 with overtime); Q4 already at peak
Cure time	Klassik 5 days; Maison formulation 14 days
Vessels	MOQ 5,000/order; 16-week lead time; 2027 capacity slot must be reserved by 15 Sep 2026; 2027 plan needs ~8,000 vessels
Fragrance	Grasse house MOQ 25 kg per scent (~830 candles/scent); 6 launch scents planned
Refill system	€38 RRP, 71% gross margin, tooling included above

YOUR TASK

The board of Manufaktur Lichtwerk GmbH engages you to answer, in one integrated recommendation:

1. **The strategic question.** Should Lichtwerk reposition from premium to luxury — fully, partially, or not at all? Take one clear position.
2. **The design.** Recommend the brand architecture (one brand, sub-brand, or separate brand), the pricing ladder, and the channel strategy — explicitly including Amazon, the 380 wholesale doors, B2B white label, Hansen & Cie., and the Neuer Wall option.
3. **The numbers.** Quantify a three-year revenue and contribution trajectory (bridge from €6.8m), the funding requirement, and your recommended funding source — including a clear stance on the Compagnie Sévigné approach.
4. **The sequence.** An 18-month milestone plan with the three September–November deadlines resolved, KPIs, and **explicit kill criteria**.
5. **The people.** Address the founders' disagreement with a workable governance proposal (who leads what, with which decision rights).

Deliverables and rules. (a) A 3-minute uninterrupted opening pitch — recommendation first, then rationale; hard stop at 3:00. (b) One summary slide (16:9) shown during the pitch. (c) A one-page black-and-white judge brief (A4, one side, ≥10.5 pt) handed to the board beforehand — write it as a genuine board pre-read: recommendation, key numbers, risks, asks. (d) Appendix slides in the same .pptx deck — unlimited per ABCC rules — for use only in the discussion, never in the 3-minute pitch. All four team members must contribute during the 25 minutes. Preparation: 4 hours; internet research allowed, including databases and generative AI, per official ABCC rules; no coach contact, no phones or smartwatches. This round carries 30% of the total competition score.

=== TEACHING NOTE (coach only) ===

Do not distribute below this line to the team before the debrief.

Purpose and Learning Objectives

This case trains the specific muscles the Boardroom round rewards: (1) taking one defensible position under genuine ambiguity; (2) compressing it into 3 minutes, one slide and one page; (3) surviving 22 minutes of role-played board pressure, including an interpersonal (founder-conflict) dimension most case teams ignore; (4) grounding brand strategy — normally hand-wavy — in unit economics and operating constraints. The premium-to-luxury question is deliberately chosen because it punishes both timid answers ("do a pilot") and naive ones ("raise all prices, exit all channels").

Solution Sketch (a strong modal answer — not the only defensible one)

Headline: "Yes to a luxury line; no to a luxury company — yet." Build **Maison Lichtwerk** as a ring-fenced elevated line with its own codes, while protecting and quietly upgrading the premium core that funds it.

- **Brand architecture.** Endorsed sub-brand ("Maison Lichtwerk, Hamburg" with distinct vessel, typography, packaging world), not a full rebrand and not a disconnected new name. Rationale: Edition Eins shows the existing brand can stretch for Aesthetes and new luxury buyers (38% new-to-brand), while the survey's €44 ceiling shows the mass of current customers will not follow — so the core must remain intact. The Speicherstadt/maritime-trade provenance is the storytelling asset that makes a German luxury claim credible.
- **Brand hygiene before brand elevation (first 6 months).** Exit Amazon (forgoing ~€71k contribution = 21% CM on €0.34m — cheap insurance; assume 25–30% migrates to DTC), shut down the grey market via authorized-dealer enforcement, end sitewide vouchers (the 28% Edition Eins redemption is disqualifying in luxury), prune the wholesale tail from 380 to ~150–180 curated doors over 18 months (cutting ~200 tail doors ≈ €0.7–0.8m revenue at 22% CM ≈ €160–180k contribution, phased).
- **Maison go-to-market.** DTC-led (the Exhibit 2 punchline: Maison wholesale margin at luxury trade terms is €6.72/unit = 19% — selective retail is marketing, DTC is the profit pool). Accept Hansen & Cie. shop-in-shop as the credibility beachhead; **defer Neuer Wall** to year 2 and let the option lapse (removes €450k, converting the €1.4m need into ~€0.95m); upgrade the Ottensen atelier as the interim brand temple.
- **Core moves.** Reprice Klassik to €42–44 with upgraded packaging at the next collection change (survey median €44 = headroom); keep B2B but firewall it (separate ops identity, no "Lichtwerk" on white-label product; it is 17% of revenue and 26% CM — killing it is vanity, flaunting it is brand damage).
- **Funding.** ~€0.95m phased need vs €0.61m cash + ~€0.4m annual EBITDA: fund with a Kf W/house-bank facility of €0.6–0.8m plus operating cash; **decline Sévigné now, politely and formally, keeping the relationship warm** — 1.2× revenue undervalues the option being built, but revisit after Maison proof points (a strong team may set a "re-engage trigger": Maison >€1.5m run-rate).
- **Governance.** Merle leads Maison with a ring-fenced P&L and budget; Johanna remains group CEO owning core + cash; advisory board reviews Maison at two gates (post-launch season 1, month 18) against pre-agreed kill criteria: sell-through <55% in two consecutive seasons, refill attach <15%, Maison contribution margin <35%, or core revenue decline >10% → stop or restructure.
- **Bridge (illustrative year-3):** €6.8m core base +4% growth +€0.3m Klassik repricing flow-through − €0.34m Amazon − ~€0.8m wholesale pruning + €2.9m Maison plan (haircut a strong team applies: 60–70% of plan) ≈ €8.5–9.0m revenue at a richer blended margin.

Alternative defensible answers (score on argument quality, not branch choice): (A) full two-brand separation with outside capital — defensible only with the Sévigné money and control safeguards; (B) refuse the luxury tier, premiumize the core to €44–49 and win the "honest premium" position — defensible if the team confronts the Rituals squeeze and gives Merle something real; (C) accept Sévigné — defensible with governance terms and a use-of-funds plan. Indefensible: "run another pilot and decide later" (the September deadline exists precisely to kill this).

Deliberate analytical trap planted in the exhibits: the founders' assumed 60% blended Maison margin is inconsistent with their own 70/30 channel mix — 0.7 × 63% + 0.3 × 19% ≈ **50%.** Teams that catch and correct this (or push the mix toward DTC) should be credited loudly in the debrief.

Premiumization / Luxury Levers to Expect

Strong teams will select and sequence a subset — not recite all: price integrity (no vouchers, no outlet, MAP enforcement); distribution scarcity and door curation; product codes (vessel, weight, numbering, signature, unboxing); provenance narrative (Speicherstadt, Grasse, Bavarian Forest glass); waitlists and numbered editions; experiential retail and clienteling for the top decile; refill system framed as sustainability-as-luxury; PR/editorial and tastemaker seeding replacing performance ads; collaborations with credible adjacents

(perfumer-signed editions, design institutions); service rituals (engraving, candle-care ceremony); selective internationalization (one city, one wholesale partner) only after domestic proof.

How the Judges Will Attack

Brief the four judges into roles and instruct them to interrupt from minute 4: **Johanna** (defends the cash engine, attacks every revenue cut with P&L questions), **Merle** (tests conviction and taste; hates half-measures), **Dr. Sander** (luxury orthodoxy: "luxury is earned, not declared"; attacks price architecture and distribution logic), **Hauke** (investor lens: cash, dilution, downside, "why not take the €2.5m?"). Standard escalation pattern: numbers first, then evidence, then brand logic, then governance, then a curveball (recession, Rituals launching a €45 "atelier" line, wax inflation). The 22 minutes reward dialogue — teams should answer, ask the board a question back at least once, and visibly arbitrate between the founders rather than around them.

Ten Likely Judge Questions, with Strong Answers Sketched

1. **"You cut Amazon and 200 doors. Bridge me from €6.8m to your year-3 number."** Strong answer: a memorized five-line bridge (core +4%, +€0.3m repricing, −€0.34m Amazon with 25–30% DTC recapture, −€0.8m phased tail pruning at only 22% CM, +Maison at a stated haircut to plan), delivered in euros of *contribution*, not just revenue — noting the pruned revenue is the company's worst-margin revenue.
2. **"Diptyque needed six decades and Paris. Why does a Hamburg brand founded in 2015 get €95?"** Strong answer: we are not claiming heritage, we are claiming provenance and craft — the two attributes where we already outscore Diptyque in their own survey (craftsmanship 66 vs 55); Hamburg's 300-year scent-trade story is unoccupied territory; Edition Eins is empirical evidence (sell-out, 38% new buyers, <1% returns) that the claim converts.
3. **"Your own survey says the median acceptable price is €44 and only 24% call you luxury. Isn't the market saying no?"** Strong answer: the €44 median describes the *current* customer base and the *current* brand codes — that is exactly why we ring-fence Maison rather than rebrand; the decision-relevant numbers are the 27% intent in the luxury-buyer subsample and 44% consideration among Aesthetes, the segments Maison targets.
4. **"Doesn't the €39 candle cap the €95 one if they share a name?"** Strong answer: endorsement, not fusion — separate vessel language, packaging, channel and no shared promotions; precedent logic (masstige-to-luxury ladders work when codes are separated); and the €39 core is the trust asset that supplied 41% of pilot buyers — a new cold-start brand would cost more than the €1.4m plan.
5. **"Why €95 and 300 g? You land at €31.7/100 g — below Trudon, at Jo Malone's level. Is that luxury or upper premium?"** Strong answer: deliberate entry-luxury anchoring — priced at the credibility threshold where the German provenance story is believable, with headroom architecture above it (numbered editions €140–180) to pull the range upward; per-gram games matter less than absolute price points and codes; revisit at repricing gate after season 2.
6. **"Merle wants the full pivot, Johanna doesn't. What do we do on Monday, and who runs Maison?"** Strong answer: name the conflict explicitly and resolve it structurally — Merle owns Maison P&L and creative authority within a budget, Johanna owns group and cash, advisory board owns the two review gates with pre-agreed kill criteria; the plan gives each founder the thing they are right about.
7. **"Show me the cash-flow trough. What if Maison year 1 comes in at half plan?"** Strong answer: quantified trough (peak funding need ~€0.9–1.0m in mid-2027 after deferring the flagship, against €0.61m cash + facility); at 50% of plan the loss is bounded to inventory (~€150k write-down exposure, mitigated by 5,000-vessel MOQ discipline and refill compatibility) and the kill criteria trigger before tranche 2.
8. **"MOQ 5,000 vessels, 16-week lead, 14-day cure, Q4 already at capacity. Walk me through the critical path."** Strong answer: backward schedule from an October 2027 launch (slot reservation 15 Sep 2026 → vessel delivery spring 2027 → pour/cure Maison in the Q2–Q3 capacity valley, deliberately counter-seasonal → buffer stock pre-Q4); overtime and one artisan hire cover peak; this is precisely why the decision cannot wait.
9. **"Our biggest B2B client buys white label at decent margin. Luxury houses don't do that. Keep or kill?"** Strong answer: keep, firewall, and cap — it is €1.16m revenue and ~€300k contribution funding the transition; remove brand traces, run it as "Ottensen Atelier GmbH"-style contract manufacturing, cap it at ~15% of revenue, and revisit once Maison replaces its contribution; killing it now is aesthetic self-harm.
10. **"Why grind it out alone instead of taking Sévigné's €2.5m and their distribution?"** Strong answer: sequencing, not pride — at 1.2× revenue, pre-proof, the dilution buys what 18 months of execution creates anyway; the deadlines don't require their capital (post-flagship-deferral need is fundable with debt); respond formally by October with a defined re-engagement trigger, because a warm Sévigné is also the exit option Hauke deserves an answer on.

Traps and Red Flags

1. **The overnight rebrand** — migrating the whole brand to luxury, vaporising the €44-ceiling customer base that pays the salaries.
2. **"Luxury = higher prices"** — repricing without codes, scarcity or service; judges will quote Dr. Sander: luxury is earned.
3. **Keeping Amazon "because it grows at 21%"** while pitching a luxury story — instant credibility loss in discussion.
4. **Killing B2B for aesthetics** — surrendering ~€300k of contribution with nothing to replace it.
5. **Financing hand-waving** — no bridge, no trough, no source of the €1.4m; or accepting Sévigné without touching valuation or control.
6. **Ignoring the survey ceiling** — assuming current Ritualists trade up to €95 (their stated consideration: 12%).
7. **Missing the ops critical path** — recommending a 2027 launch without the 15 September vessel reservation, or scheduling Maison pours into the Q4 capacity peak.
8. **Swallowing the 60% margin assumption** — not catching the founders' 50%-vs-60% blended-margin inconsistency, or proposing heavy luxury wholesale despite the €6.72/19% unit economics.
9. **A 3-minute pitch that tours the analysis** instead of leading with the recommendation; or a judge brief that is a shrunken slide deck rather than a board pre-read.
10. **Treating the 22 minutes as a defense** — answering only the question asked, never engaging the founder conflict, never addressing Johanna and Merle as people with names.

Scoring Rubric (100 points)

Criterion	Pts	What excellent looks like
Opening pitch (3 min)	10	Recommendation in the first 30 seconds; three numbered reasons; lands at 2:50–3:00; confident handoffs
Summary slide	5	One message, readable at 4 m; the recommendation and 3–4 proof numbers; no clutter
One-page judge brief	10	Genuine board pre-read: decision requested, key economics, risks with mitigations, explicit asks/deadlines; clean b/w typography
Strategic recommendation	25	One clear position; coherent brand architecture, pricing and channel design; all three deadlines and Sévigné resolved; addresses both founders' truths
Analytical & financial rigor	20	Uses the exhibits; revenue/contribution bridge; funding plan with trough; catches the margin inconsistency and the wholesale unit-economics trap
Boardroom discussion	25	Composure under interruption; concedes gracefully, defends with numbers; dialogue not monologue; arbitrates the founder conflict; all four members contribute substantively
Team presence & professionalism	5	Role clarity, no internal contradiction, board-appropriate tone
Total	**100**	

Bands: 85+ outstanding (would win the round) · 70–84 strong · 55–69 competent but beatable · <55 rework fundamentals.

Debrief Prompts (45 minutes, suggested)

1. Replay the first 30 seconds of the pitch: was the recommendation audible, specific, and priced?
2. Which judge question caused visible re-grouping, and what pre-built appendix page would have absorbed it?
3. Did anyone say "Johanna, you are right about X; Merle, you are right about Y"? If not, why not — that sentence is the round.
4. Read the one-pager as a real board member: could you decide from it alone?
5. Score against the rubric independently, then reconcile — calibrate before the real 30%-weight round.